Scheduled or Seen? Twelve Things to Notice When Help Comes to Dad's House

Everyday things to notice and write down about the help Dad gets, without judging anyone.

The schedule tells you what was arranged. This guide is for the other half: what you can see for yourself at Dad's house, and what you hear when you ask. It names twelve things to notice and, for each, what to write down.

Write down what you see and hear, and stop there. Don't interpret, and don't grade anyone. “No visit seen Wednesday” is a line to ask about, not a finding. What any of it means for Dad is a question for the people who assess him. Medicare's booklet for people getting home health care from a Medicare-certified agency includes a checklist to help a person, and the family or friends helping, monitor that care. This page starts from the same idea. The twelve items and the wording about what to write down are ours.

The visits

1 Who came, and when [1]

NOTICE The days and times help arrived this week, and who it was: an aide, a nurse, a therapist, your sister, a neighbor.

WRITE DOWN A week's log: day, time, who. Put “seen” beside the visits you or someone you can name was there for.

2 The visits nobody in the family saw

NOTICE Visits that are on the schedule for hours when no one from the family is at the house.

WRITE DOWN “Scheduled, not seen,” and who could tell you about it: Dad, the agency's office, the person who visits.

3 A different person or a different day [2] [1]

NOTICE A substitute at the door, or a visit moved to another day or time.

WRITE DOWN Who came, which day, and whether Dad knew ahead of time. Don't decide what it means.

The tasks

4 What gets done during a visit [3]

NOTICE The everyday tasks on Dad's plan that you see done while help is there: a bath, getting dressed, a meal, the housework.

WRITE DOWN The tasks you saw, by day. Leave the others blank. Blank means “not seen” and nothing more.

5 **Around the house** [4]

NOTICE What a visitor can see: food in the kitchen, the state of the rooms, whether his medications are on hand.

WRITE DOWN What you saw and the date, as plain facts. A medication question goes to his pharmacist or prescriber. Change nothing yourself.

The help that isn't on any schedule

6 **What your sister covers** [5]

NOTICE The things she does for Dad, by day and time of day, including the ones she doesn't mention.

WRITE DOWN Her week as she tells it. Show her what you wrote and ask what you missed.

7 **Tasks that appear twice**

NOTICE Anything that is on the plan as someone else's job and also in your sister's week.

WRITE DOWN The task and both names. It's a question to ask, not a conclusion.

8 **How she says she's doing** [6]

NOTICE What she tells you when you ask: tired, short on sleep, no time for herself, or “Thanks, but I'm fine.”

WRITE DOWN Her words and the date. Not your reading of them.

Dad's side of it

9 **Dad's own account** [4]

NOTICE What Dad says about his week when you ask him directly: who came, what they did, what he'd have liked a hand with.

WRITE DOWN His words first, before anyone else's version.

10 **Company and the things he enjoys** [7] [2]

NOTICE The part of the week that isn't a task: visitors, conversation, getting out, the things Dad likes to do.

WRITE DOWN What happened this week, and what he says he'd like more of. That part is his choice.

Notes and messages

11 **What gets written down at the house** [2] [5]

NOTICE Whether there is a log, a notebook or a visit sheet at Dad's, and who writes in it.

WRITE DOWN Where it's kept, who writes in it, and the last date on it.

12 How word travels when something changes [1]

NOTICE The last time something changed (a visit moved, a new instruction from the doctor): who told the family, and who told the people who help.

WRITE DOWN The change, who heard about it and from whom, and anyone who didn't hear.

When it's a call, not a note

This page is about the help, not about Dad's health. If something you notice leaves you concerned about how Dad himself is doing, that is a call to his doctor or nurse, not a line in the log. The National Institute on Aging's advice to families is to suggest a visit to a health care provider when they're concerned about a person's physical or mental health. In an emergency, call emergency services.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't tell you what any of the twelve means, whether a service has fallen short, or whether Dad's help is enough. It doesn't measure your sister or anyone else. It leaves you with a week of plain notes, and those go to the people who assess him.

Ready for the next step?

You have a week of notes on the help that arrives and the help that fills in. The care interview gives those notes a place: it goes through Dad's daily life area by area, asks who covers each part, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Medicare & Home Health Care (CMS Product No. 10969)
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hiring In-Home Help
3. Administration for Community Living, What is Long-Term Care?
4. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
5. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
6. National Institute on Aging, Taking Care of Yourself: Tips for Caregivers
7. National Institute on Aging, Participating in Activities You Enjoy As You Age